



Western China and Mongolia

CHINA IS A LAND of great geographical diversity and amazing landscapes. More than 90 percent of the population are Han Chinese—descendants of people who settled here more than 5,000 years ago. This region includes western China, Mongolia, and Tibet. Mongolia gained its independence from China in 1911 and is now an independent democracy. Tibet is currently governed by China. Compared with eastern China, this region is sparsely populated and characterized by vast deserts, remote mountains, and extreme temperatures.

DESERT LANDS

The cold, rocky Gobi Desert (right) stretches for more than 380,000 sq miles (1,000,000 sq km) through Mongolia and northeast China. Many dinosaur bones and eggs have been found here, making it one of the richest dinosaur fossil regions in the world.

THE MONGOLIANS

Most of the people living in Mongolia are Khalkh Mongols. About 70 percent of Mongols now live in urban areas, but some still lead traditional lives as nomadic herders. They live in large felt tents, called *yurts*. Smoke from the central iron stove escapes through a chimney in the roof.



In traditional Mongolian khoomi singing, men are able to sing several notes at once.

兒童百科全書

CHINESE WRITING

The Chinese alphabet is not made up of letters. Instead, separate symbols stand for individual words or parts of words. There are more than 50,000 characters in the Chinese language. The same symbols are used everywhere in China, and no matter what Chinese language or dialect people speak, they can all read the same script.

Chinese symbols, whose strokes have to be written in a certain order



MONASTERIES IN MONGOLIA

Under communism, Mongolians were forbidden to practice their traditional Buddhist faith, which was viewed as superstitious and unscientific. Since the democratic government was set up in 1990, some monasteries have reopened. Many people, however, no longer follow any religion.